

**THREE'S A CROWD?** Yogi with deputy CMs Maurya and Pathak

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

# TRIANGLE WITH A SLIGHT SIDE PAIN

**Upper storeys upset in UP? There have been signs for a while, but the absence of Yogi's two deputy CMs from a high-profile event in Ayodhya made it conspicuous. How will balance be restored?**

place in the programme run sheet. The ads, issued by the state information department and published in all major newspapers, featured photos of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the CM, along with state tourism minister Jaiveer Singh and Ayodhya's minister-in-charge Surya Pratap Shahi.

Even Governor Anandiben Patel's name was left out. Some sought to explain it away as "administrative oversight", but most aren't buying that, and insiders say the omissions have touched a raw nerve. Both deputy CMs are said to have conveyed their displeasure to the party's top leadership.

## INVERTED PYRAMID

As it stands, the episode has deepened perceptions of strain and asymmetry in the state's power pyramid—between CM Adityanath, his ministers and a bureaucracy that many of them privately accuse of running the government with little political consultation. Murmurs about differences between the government and the party's state unit had grown audible after the BJP's below-par performance in last year's Lok Sabha election. Just a month after that, Maurya had flung a none-too-veiled swipe at Yogi's style of functioning, saying "the party is bigger than the government". Around then, he also skipped several cabinet meetings chaired by the CM—before later praising him publicly that August.

Maurya's recent appointment as Bihar's poll co-incharge, and the public endorsement he got from Union home minister Amit Shah—who called him "my friend"—has only sharpened the sense of intrigue. As an aside, it also allowed Maurya's aides to attribute his absence in Ayodhya to his political commitments in Bihar, by way of scotching any perceived belittlement.

Not that it was necessary. For the state BJP, Maurya has for years been an essential figure in terms of both symbolism and strategy. As a long-time swayamsevak, he has had what the brotherhood would deem a textbook political journey: beginning in the 1980s, he has expended his labour in the RSS, Bajrang Dal and the Vishwa Hindu Parishad. He was among the karsevaks who mobilised during the Ram temple movement, and in a way his rise mirrored the BJP's own expansion across the Hindi heartland.

## THE OBC FACTOR

On top of that, the caste factor favours Maurya—it was his appointment as state BJP chief in 2016, at the relatively young age of 46, that signalled his arrival as one of the party's most prominent OBC faces. He was still in his first flush then, having debuted in the assembly from Sirathu in 2012 and then won the Phulpur Lok Sabha seat in 2014.

Confirmation of his rising stature came when he was named as a deputy CM in 2022 though he had lost the assembly contest from home base Sirathu. That signalled his core value: as a non-Yadav OBC with a grassroots connect, he taps a crucial segment of the BJP's social base in UP. But more than an organisational bridge, his tacit role was as a political counterweight within the Yogi government.

Talk of tension between Yogi and Maurya persists, but just days after the Deepotsav snafu, the CM and Pathak were seen together at a Chhath Puja in Lucknow—smiling, exchanging courtesies, projecting unity.

Pathak ticks a different box in the BJP's UP equation. With an eclectic political background—first Congress, then twice a BSP